

India launches nuclear attack against Pakistan amid intense ground war

The attack targeted Pakistan's nuclear weapons facilities, casualties likely in hundreds of thousands

DELHI—India launched a barrage of nuclear weapons at Pakistan late last night, targeting locations suspected of hosting its long-range nuclear missiles. The attack comes months after India invaded Pakistan-controlled Kashmir, setting off a grueling ground war.

The World Health Organization warned that while the number of casualties from Monday's attack are difficult to estimate, it may reach into the hundreds of thousands. The long-term effects of radiation on humans and the environment are unknown but expected to be severe.

In a statement posted on social media, the Prime Minister wrote that he authorized the attack to prevent Pakistan from striking an Indian city with a nuclear weapon. Although there was no indication that such an attack was imminent, he said that disabling Pakistan's nuclear capabilities was

necessary to ensure India could take territory in Kashmir without risking excessive Indian casualties.

According to Indian government officials speaking on the condition of anonymity, it is unclear whether all of Pakistan's estimated 170 strategic nuclear weapons were destroyed in the attack but the risk of retaliation is low. In addition to targeting its warheads, India struck the airfields and missile launchers that Pakistan would use in a large-scale counter-attack.

Low chance of retaliation, according to government officials

India's nuclear salvo marks a new chapter in what has been an intense months-long conflict with Pakistan. After a terrorist group backed by Pakistani intelligence services killed three hundred and forty three civilians in a multiday attack in Delhi, India responded by sending troops into Pakistan-controlled Kashmir. After initially seizing thousands of square kilometers of territory, India's gains have slowed and even reversed in some areas along the frontline. Meanwhile, casualties mounted on both sides of the war. According to a leaked Indian intelligence assessment, both India and Pakistan have lost over twenty thousand soldiers in the war, excluding deaths from Monday's attack.

It remains unclear whether Pakistan will surrender.